

KS3: CAUSES OF THE GREAT WAR

How did decades of imperial rivalry and fear culminate in thirty days of madness?

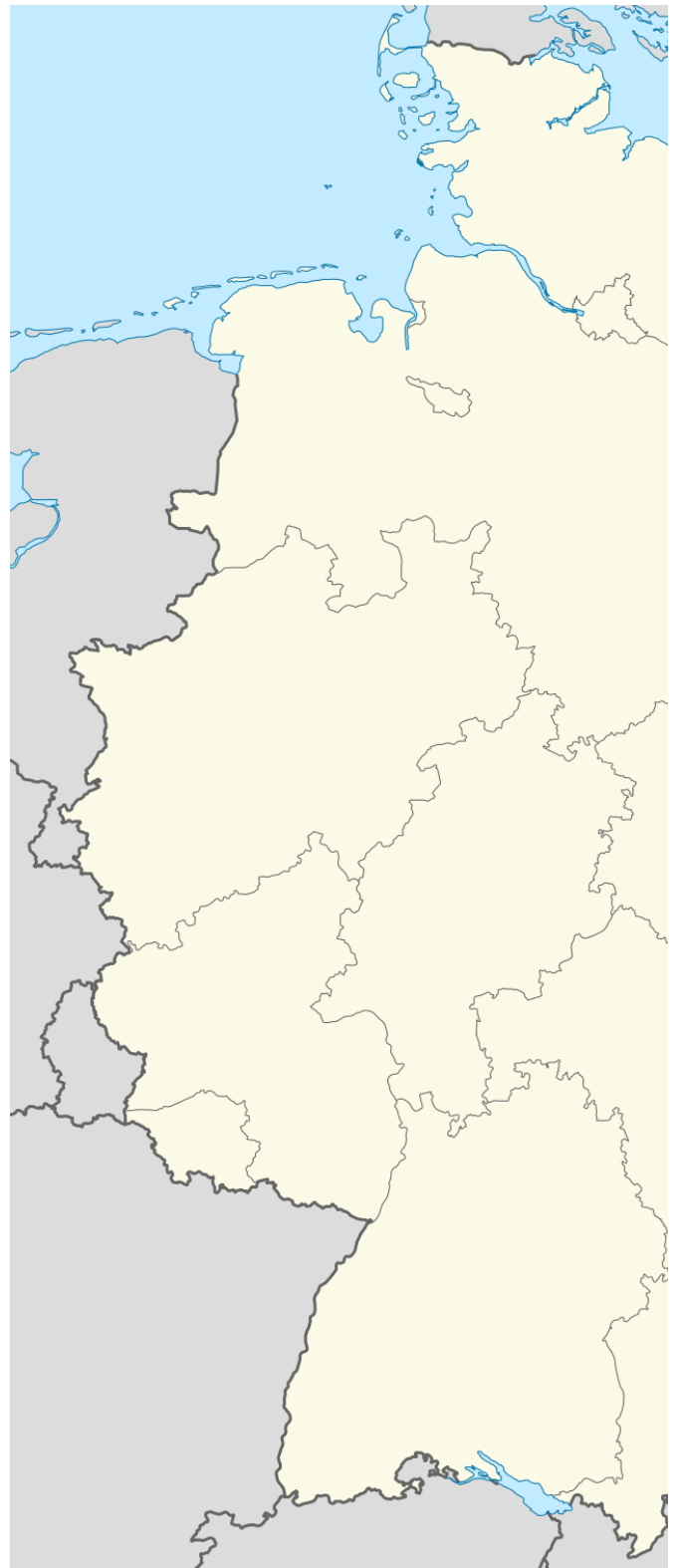
Name: _____

Class: _____

Progress & Assessment Tracker	Effort	Level	Teacher Comments
L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?			
L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?			
L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?			
L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?			
L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?			
L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?			
Assessment: Assessment Option 1: The July Crisis Domino Flowchart			
Assessment: Assessment Option 2: The M.A.I.N. Significance Diamond			
Assessment: Assessment Option 3: Source Utility Analysis			
Assessment: Assessment Option 4: The Historians' Debate			
Final Unit Grade:			

L1: How was the German Empire created in 1871?

IAN REICH
-1918



LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand how Otto von Bismarck used 'blood and iron' to unify the German states.
- ☐ Analyze the geographical impact of the new German Empire on the balance of power in Europe.

- ☐ Understand how Otto von Bismarck used 'blood and iron' to unify the German states.
 - ☐ Analyze the geographical impact of the new German Empire on the balance of power in Europe.

Source A : Map of the German Empire vs Modern Germany

A map showing the newly created German Empire in 1871 (left) compared to modern-day Germany (right).

Q1. Look at the A4 map provided. Why might the geographical location of the new German Empire cause fear for both Germany and its neighbors?

Q2. Interpreting 'Blood and Iron'. In your own words, explain what Otto von Bismarck meant when he said Germany would be united by 'blood and iron'. How did Prussia use its industrial and military power to prove Bismarck's speech right between 1864 and 1871? [p. 4]

Q3. The Steps to Unification. Create a three-step staircase diagram in your book to show how Bismarck built the German Empire. For each step, write down: 1. The name of the country Prussia defeated. 2. The year of the war. 3. How this war helped Prussia achieve its ultimate goal of unification. [p. 5]

[illegible]

Lesson Consolidation

Reflect on today's learning and answer your teacher's final challenge.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

General Notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no vertical margin lines or other markings present. The paper appears to be a standard sheet of notebook paper.☐ Emerging (1-2)☐ Emerging+ (3)☐ Expected (4-5)☐ Expected+ (6-7)☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L2: How did the Franco-Prussian War create a lasting legacy of hatred?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the penalties forced upon France in 1871.
- ☐ Explain how the Ems Telegram sparked the Franco-Prussian War.
- ☐ Evaluate the long-term impact on European relations.

Source A : Anton von Werner, 'The Proclamation of the German Empire at Versailles', painted in 1885.

What is this source showing? This painting depicts the official birth of the unified German Empire inside the Hall of Mirrors at the Palace of Versailles in 1871. France was defeated and forced to host this ceremony in its own royal palace. This created a deep, lasting feeling of humiliation and anger in France, leading to a desire for revenge (revanche) that would eventually help spark WWI.

Q1. What are the two opposing figures doing in this 1871 painting by Anton von Werner, and why is this event significant?

Chronological Domino Flowchart

Score: / 5

Task: The historical events below are out of order. Read them carefully, then use your pen to **draw arrows connecting the boxes** in the correct chronological and causal order (Event A → Event B → Event C...).

June 1914

The Spark in Sarajevo

The Assassination of the Archduke

1871

The Unification of Germany

The Franco-Prussian War

1907

Encirclement & Alliances

The Triple Entente System

1897

Imperial Rivalries

The Place in the Sun speech

1906

The Naval Arms Race

The Launch of HMS Dreadnought

1. Looking at this long-term timeline, which factor do you think was the most dangerous necessary cause of the war?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Alsace-Lorraine | Ems Telegram | Reparations | Siege

Your Sentence:

Q3. To what extent did the maps of central Europe fundamentally change prior to 1871? Use the term "North German Confederation" in your answer. [p. 8]

Q4. Describe the diplomatic trick Chancellor Otto von Bismarck used to manufacture a war with France in 1870. [p. 8]

Q5. Identify two distinct military advantages that allowed the Prussian-led German army to quickly defeat the conventional French forces. [p. 8]

Q6. List the three severe penalties forced upon France by the victorious German Empire in the 1871 peace treaty. [p. 8]

Q7. Explain why the loss of Alsace-Lorraine and the ceremony at Versailles created a long-term "nightmare" for European peace. [p. 9]

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Of the three penalties forced upon France in the 1871 treaty (loss of land, 5 billion franc fine, German occupation), which do you think caused the most bitter resentment, and why?

Think: Jot down your choice and one strong reason to support it.

Your Notes:

Writing Practice

Q8. Evaluate how the change in leadership from Bismarck to Kaiser Wilhelm II fundamentally altered Germany's strategic position in Europe.

Q9. How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the reasons for French hatred of Germany after 1871?

"We must never forget the humiliation of 1871. The German Empire was proclaimed in our own Palace of Versailles, tearing away the bleeding wounds of Alsace and Lorraine. They have stolen our iron and our factories, and forced us to pay a crushing ransom of 5 billion francs. Every French child must grow up with one single thought: to rebuild our army and take back what was stolen from the motherland."

Source A: Adapted from a French school textbook, published in Paris, 1885.

"France will never forgive us for taking Alsace-Lorraine. The peace we have forced upon them has left a bitter resentment that will not fade. We must accept that a French war of revenge is a certainty in the future. Therefore, our entire diplomatic focus must be to ensure she never finds an ally to help her take it back. As long as France remains diplomatically isolated, particularly from Russia, Germany will remain secure."

Source B: Adapted from a private letter written by German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck to a fellow diplomat, 1872.

General Notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no vertical margin lines or other markings present. The paper appears to be a standard sheet of notebook paper.☐ Emerging (1-2)

☐ Emerging+ (3)

☐ Expected (4-5)

☐ Expected+ (6-7)☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L3: To what extent did the 'Scramble for Africa' increase tension in Europe?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the main European colonial powers and their territories.
- ☐ Explain how Kaiser Wilhelm II's 'Place in the Sun' policy threatened Britain.
- ☐ Evaluate the impact of the Moroccan Crises on the Entente Cordiale.

Source A : John Tenniel, 'The Greedy Boy', a British political cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1885.

What is this source showing? This British cartoon satirizes Germany's Chancellor Otto von Bismarck as a "greedy boy" grabbing slices of a pudding that represents colonial territories in Africa and New Guinea. This reflects British anxiety and suspicion about Germany's aggressive efforts to build a global empire, which threatened Britain's status as the world's leading power.

Q1. Look closely at the man standing over Africa. What is his posture suggesting about imperial ambitions?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Who was the first Emperor of the newly unified Germany in 1871?

2. Which brilliant Chancellor united the German states?

3. Which country was humiliatingly defeated in the Franco-Prussian War?

4. What strategic border territory did Germany take in 1871?

5. What is the French word for their desire for revenge?

6. Explain how Bismarck used the Ems Telegram to trap France into a war.

7. Detail the two military advantages the Prussian army possessed.

8. Why was the location of the German Empire's proclamation so humiliating for France?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Imperialism**

Q3. Explain two distinct economic reasons why possessing overseas colonies was vital to the industrial growth of a Great Power. [p. 14]

Q4. Why did French politicians feel it was absolutely vital to maintain a firm hold on their remaining global colonies after 1871? [p. 14]

Q5. Explain how Germany’s sudden desire to build a naval fleet to protect its new colonies acted as a cause of friction with Great Britain. [p. 14]

Q6. What specific geographical territory did Foreign Secretary Bernhard von Bülow target when he demanded a "place in the sun" for Germany? [p. 14]

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: If you were a British politician in 1897, would you view Kaiser Wilhelm's 'Place in the Sun' speech as a direct threat, or just a young leader showing off? Why?

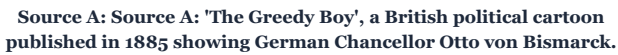
Think: Jot down your view and one piece of evidence.

Your Notes:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.



Source A: Source A: 'The Greedy Boy', a British political cartoon published in 1885 showing German Chancellor Otto von Bismarck.



Source B: Speech by German Foreign Minister Bernhard von Bülow to the Reichstag, 1897.

General Notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no vertical margin lines or other markings present. The paper appears to be a standard sheet of notebook paper.☐ Emerging (1-2)

☐ Emerging+ (3)

☐ Expected (4-5)

☐ Expected+ (6-7)☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L4: Why did a battleship building contest destroy Anglo-German relations?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the significance of the HMS Dreadnought.
- ☐ Explain the concept of the Two-Power Standard and Risk Theory.
- ☐ Analyze how naval competition fed mutual suspicion.

Source A : Official technical blueprint showing the design and armament of HMS Dreadnought, published in 1906.

What is this source showing? This is a technical naval diagram of HMS Dreadnought, a revolutionary British battleship launched in 1906. It was so fast and heavily armed that it instantly made all existing warships in the world obsolete (useless). This triggered a frantic naval arms race between Britain and Germany, as both countries rushed to build as many Dreadnoughts as possible.

Q1. This blueprint represents the HMS Dreadnought. Why would this ship make all other navies obsolete?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

2. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

3. Why was the Franco-Russian Alliance a strategic disaster for Germany?

4. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

5. Describe the impact of Britain abandoning its policy of 'Splendid Isolation'.

6. Evaluate the role of Wilhelm II's personality in destabilizing Europe.

7. Who dismissed Otto von Bismarck in 1890?

8. What strategic territory did Germany take from France in 1871?

9. Why did Bismarck weave a complex web of secret alliances after 1871?

10. What was Bismarck's ultimate nightmare scenario?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Dreadnought | Arms Race | Two-Power Standard | Naval Supremacy

Britain's traditional _____ was challenged when Germany began a rapid naval buildup. This sparked a fierce _____ between the two nations. Britain relied on the _____ to maintain a massive fleet, but the invention of the heavily-armed _____ battleship reset the competition.

Q3. Describe the 'Two-Power Standard' and explain why Great Britain adhered to this strict naval policy. [p. 18]

Q4. Detail what the German Navy Laws of 1898 and 1900 explicitly ordered the German industrial shipyards to construct. [p. 19]

Q5. Explain how Admiral Tirpitz used the Navy League to manufacture civilian support and patriotism for Germany's expanding fleet. [p. 19]

Q6. Explain why maintaining a massive navy was a matter of survival for Great Britain, but was viewed as a matter of status and power for Germany. [p. 19]

Q7. Identify three specific technological features of HMS Dreadnought that made it superior to all previous warships. [p. 19]

Q8. Explain how the launching of HMS Dreadnought in 1906 represented an industrial turning point in the naval arms race, rather than maintaining the status quo. [p. 20]

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Who do you think was more to blame for the naval arms race: Germany for building a fleet they didn't strictly need, or Britain for refusing to share control of the seas?

Think: Decide who is more to blame and write down your main reason.

Your Notes:

[illegible]

Source A: Official technical blueprint of HMS Dreadnought, 1906.



Source B: Popular British political slogan chanted by the public in 1909.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

General Notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no vertical margin lines or other markings present. The paper appears to be a standard piece of stationery or notebook paper.☐ Emerging (1-2)☐ Emerging+ (3)☐ Expected (4-5)☐ Expected+ (6-7)☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L5: Did the Alliance System protect Europe or guarantee a global war?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the members of the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente.
- ☐ Explain why countries felt the need to form secret defensive treaties.
- ☐ Evaluate how the alliance system could drag all of Europe into a regional conflict.

Source A : 'The Chain of Friendship', an American cartoon published in the Brooklyn Eagle, July 1914.

What is this source showing? This cartoon shows how the complex web of alliances dragged all the European powers into war. Serbia is threatened by Austria, who is threatened by Russia, who is threatened by Germany, and so on.

Q1. Study the intertwined hands and figures in this cartoon. What does it suggest about how a local conflict might spread?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

2. What was the 'Two-Power Standard'?

3. Why did Germany feel it needed a massive high seas fleet?

4. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

5. What was the popular British slogan chanted by the public in 1909?

6. Why did Britain feel their survival depended on massive naval supremacy?

7. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

8. What was the name of Kaiser Wilhelm II's aggressive foreign policy?

9. Explain how Wilhelm II's actions during the Moroccan Crises backfired on Germany.

10. Evaluate how the 'Scramble for Africa' increased tensions in Europe.

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

Triple Entente | Triple Alliance | Reinsurance Treaty | Encirclement

Your Sentence:

Q2. Enquiry: Look at the geographical position of Germany and Austria-Hungary. Why would they feel encircled by the Triple Entente? [p. 24]

Q4. Identify the specific member countries that made up the Triple Alliance and the Triple Entente by 1907. [p. 24]

Q5. Explain the diplomatic logic of how the alliance system was theoretically supposed to keep European nations safe from a outbreak of war. [p. 25]

Q6. According to Germany's military leaders, explain why a European war was considered "inevitable and necessary" rather than avoidable. [p. 25]

Q7. Detail how the massive expansion of steel production and railway tracks across Europe altered the speed and scale of army mobilization. [p. 25]

Q8. Explain how the transformation of Europe into two "armed camps" by 1914 represented a dangerous change in international relations compared to the traditional balance of power. [p. 25]

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Imagine you are an ordinary Serbian citizen in 1908. Why would Austria-Hungary's aggressive takeover of Bosnia make you feel personally threatened?

Think: Write down how you would feel and why.

Your Notes:

[illegible]

THE BALKANS: 1914 (Simplified)

This map illustrates the political landscape of the Balkans in 1914. The Austro-Hungarian Empire is shown in orange, occupying the northern and central parts of the region. Serbia is highlighted in red, situated south of Austria-Hungary. The Ottoman Empire is depicted in dark blue, controlling the southeastern part of the Balkans. Other countries shown include Romania (light blue), Bulgaria (yellow), Greece (light green), Albania (light green), and Italy (grey). The map also shows the Black Sea to the east, the Adriatic Sea to the west, and the Aegean Sea to the south. Constantinople is marked on the coast of the Ottoman Empire. A legend in the bottom left corner identifies the colors for Austria-Hungary (orange), Serbia (red), and the Ottoman Empire (dark blue).

“Serbia is a viper that must be crushed. If we do not destroy them now, our empire will be torn apart by Slavic nationalism.”

Source B: Diary entry of the Austro-Hungarian Chief of Staff, Conrad von Hötzendorf, 1913.

General Notes

[illegible]☐ Emerging (1-2)☐ Emerging+ (3)

☐ Expected (4-5)

☐ Expected+ (6-7)☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

L6: Why did a single assassination in Sarajevo ignite a World War?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Identify the events of 28 June 1914.
- ☐ Explain how the assassination triggered the alliance system.
- ☐ Analyze whether the resulting war was inevitable or accidental.

Source A : Leonard Raven-Hill, 'The Boiling Point', a British political cartoon published in Punch Magazine, 1912.

What is this source showing? This famous cartoon represents the Balkans region as a boiling pot of ethnic and nationalistic tensions. The leaders of the European Great Powers (Britain, Germany, France, Russia, Austria-Hungary) are shown sitting on the lid, struggling to prevent the pot from exploding into a major European war.

Q1. Look at the men sitting on the 'Balkan Troubles' pot. What are they desperately trying to prevent?

Do Now Activity

Score: / 10

1. Which three countries made up the Triple Entente?

2. Which three countries made up the Triple Alliance?

3. Explain the theoretical logic of how the alliance system was supposed to keep peace.

4. Why did the alliance system actually increase paranoia instead of security?

5. What military plan did Germany create to avoid a long two-front war?

6. Which neutral country did the Schlieffen Plan require invading?

7. What feeling of being surrounded by enemies haunted German planners?

8. What revolutionary British battleship was launched in 1906?

9. Explain how the invention of the Dreadnought ironically hurt British supremacy.

10. How did the Anglo-German naval race make war more likely?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **Assassination**

Q3. Explain why the rise of independent Balkan states and Serbian nationalism represented a catastrophic nightmare for the Austro-Hungarian Empire. [p. 31]

Q4. Detail how the structural failure of the first bomb plot inadvertently led to the exact scenario where Gavrilo Princip was able to shoot the Archduke. [p. 32]

Q5. Outline the chronological sequence of events from July 23 to August 4, 1914, that transformed a local Balkan assassination into a total European war. [p. 32]

Q6. What does the desperate tone of the 'Willy-Nicky Telegrams' reveal about the monarchs' control over the escalating July Crisis? [p. 32]

Q7. Explain why it is historically inaccurate to describe the First World War strictly as a 'European' conflict in 1914. [p. 33]

Pair & Share Activity

Prompt: Look at the timeline of the July Crisis. At which exact moment do you think a world war became completely unstoppable? Was it the assassination, the blank cheque, or the mobilisations?
Think: Pick the specific turning point and write down why you chose it.

Your Notes:



Source B: The 'Blank Cheque' telegram sent from Germany to Austria-Hungary, 5 July 1914.

[illegible]

General Notes

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no vertical margin lines or other markings present. The paper appears to be a standard notebook page.☐ Emerging (1-2)☐ Emerging+ (3)☐ Expected (4-5)

☐ Expected+ (6-7)

☐ Greater Depth (8-9)

Teacher Comment:

Generated: 2026-08-12 14:34:14 UTC | Unit: great_war